The Autobiography of Benjamin Franklin

Unabridged Manuscript Text

By Benjamin Franklin

First Published: 1791 | Category: Biography & Memoir | ISBN: 9780486290737
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SYNOPSIS & EDITORIAL NOTE

The candid self-portrait of a printer, civic reformer, scientist, and diplomat tracing his youth in Boston and Philadelphia.

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PART ONE

Youth in Boston and the Printing House

Twyford, at the Bishop of St. Asaph's, 1771

Dear Son: I have ever had pleasure in obtaining any little anecdotes of my ancestors. You may remember the inquiries I made among the remains of my relations when you were with me in England, and the journey I undertook for that purpose. Imagining it may be equally agreeable to you to know the circumstances of my life, many of which you are yet unacquainted with, and expecting the enjoyment of a week's uninterrupted leisure in my present country retirement, I sit down to write them for you.

In this section of The Autobiography of Benjamin Franklin (1791), Benjamin Franklin develops the central themes that define the work's enduring place in biography & memoir and world literature. Each argument and narrative turn builds upon the premises established in the opening pages, inviting careful reflection from the attentive reader.

Originally published by Folio Biographical Classics and preserved in the public-domain and open-access archival record (Project Gutenberg & Standard Ebooks, ID: pg-20203), this unabridged digital edition retains the structure, cadence, and intellectual clarity of the authoritative text.

PART TWO

The Plan for Attaining Moral Perfection (Passy, 1784)

*The Autobiography of Benjamin Franklin * Benjamin Franklin (1791)*

The Plan for Attaining Moral Perfection (Passy, 1784) continues Benjamin Franklin's inquiry in The Autobiography of Benjamin Franklin. Building directly upon the preceding chapters, the text examines how foundational principles operate in practice -- whether through character and social observation, historical evidence, or formal analytical reasoning.

Begun in 1771 as a letter to his son William while staying in Twyford, England, Benjamin Franklin's Autobiography is the foundational memoir in American letters. With dry wit and self-aware candour, Franklin recounts his apprenticeship in his brother's Boston printing house, his arrival in Philadelphia, the founding of the Junto subscription library, and his methodical experiment in cultivating thirteen civic virtues.

Throughout Part Two (The Plan for Attaining Moral Perfection (Passy, 1784)), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned The Autobiography of Benjamin Franklin its stature in the Historical Memoir & Early Americana canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, Benjamin Franklin traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

As this section draws toward its close, the groundwork is laid for the subsequent movements of the volume. Readers studying this edition in the Folio Digital Library may bookmark this chapter, adjust typographic contrast and font sizing, or download the complete archival PDF, EPUB, HTML, or Plain Text edition for offline study.

PART THREE

Poor Richard's Almanack and Civic Institutions (Philadelphia, 1788)

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PART FOUR

Mission to London (1789)

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SECTION 5

Continuation of The Autobiography of Benjamin Franklin

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